

CITA01 – FOUNDATIONS OF CITY STUDIES SUMMER 2026

MAY 25TH, 2026

Course Instructor: Olivia Bernard

The Right to the
City

Objectives

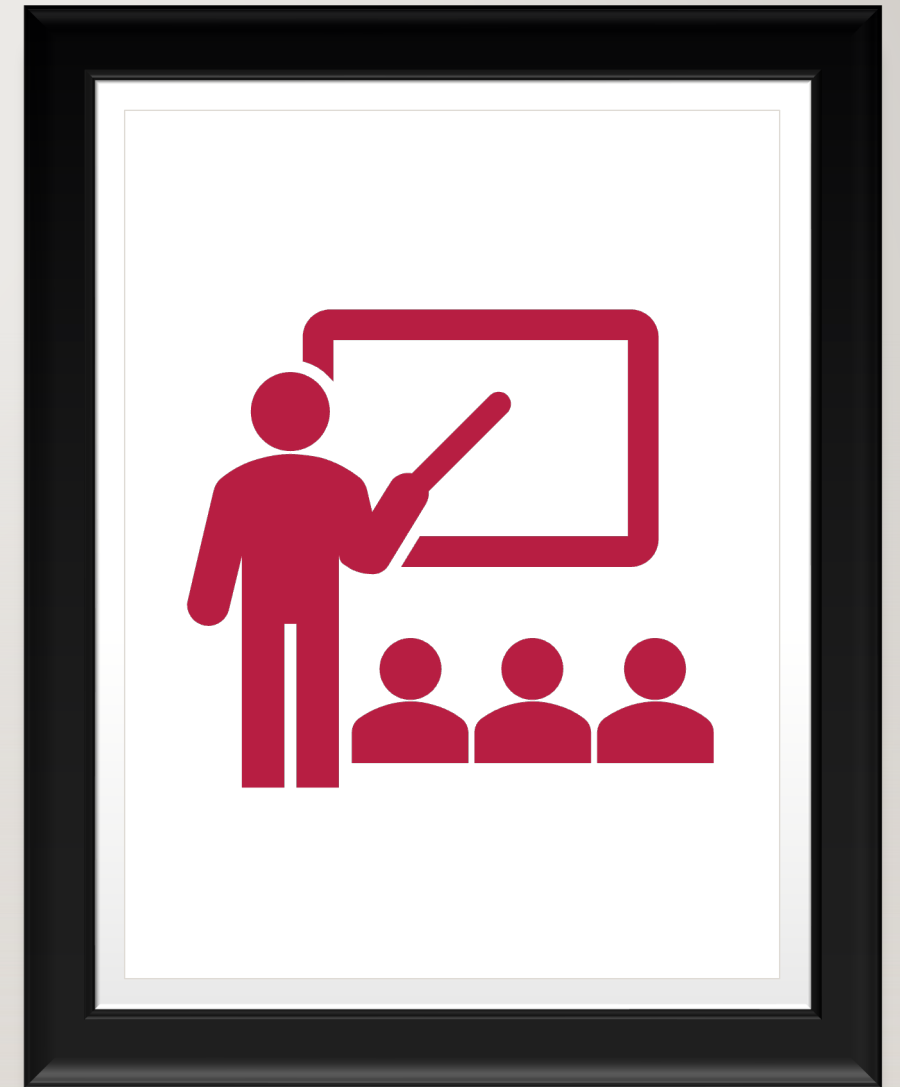
Urbanization
of Poverty

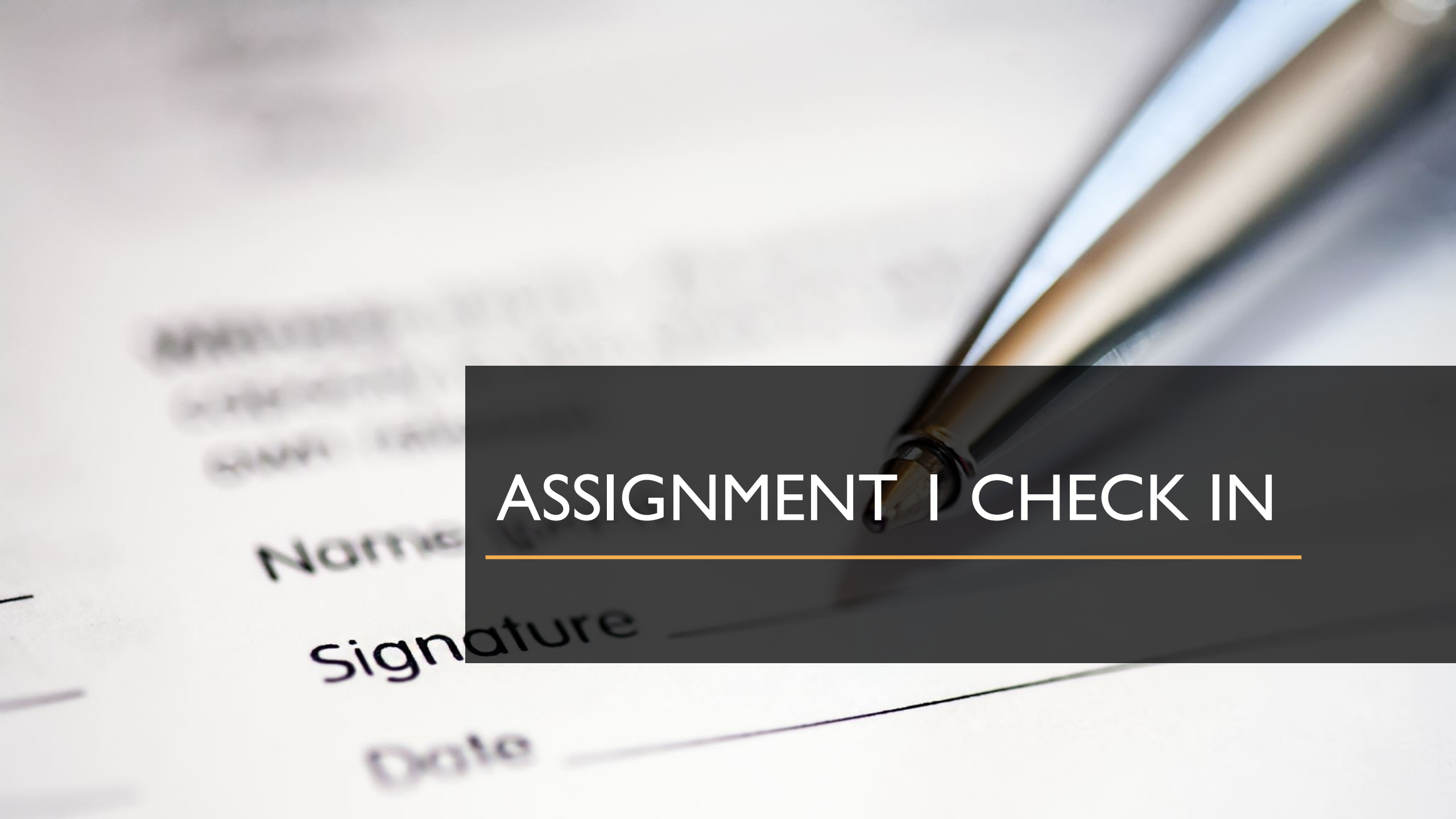
Informal
Settlements

Slum
Upgrading

Time-Space
Compression

TUTORIAL CHECK IN





ASSIGNMENT I CHECK IN

Name _____

Signature _____

Date _____

Urbanization Recap

- Urbanization

The increase over time of the proportion of the total human population that is urban as opposed to rural.

Broken down:

- A broad set of processes taking place to **transform space**
- Material, economic, and demographic **growth and development**
- Socio-material transformations in the built environment
- Connections that settlements are making with places and processes well beyond their own borders

HOW IS URBANIZATION
DEPICTED IN THE GLOBAL SOUTH
VS THE GLOBAL NORTH?

PROBLEMS OF “OVERURBANIZATION” AND RESULTING POLICY IMPLICATIONS



• LABOUR MARKETS
AND EMPLOYMENT



• HOUSING



• TRANSPORTATION
AND
INFRASTRUCTURE



• ENVIRONMENT



• GOVERNANCE
AND PLANNING

INCREMENTAL URBANIZATION

A term often used to describe forms of urban growth and change that happen “by accretion” (i.e. bit by bit). This form of urbanization can be rapid or gradual, but generally entails the production of urban space through a large number of small, cumulative and independent actions undertaken by many different people at a time.



This can take place in ‘formal’ or ‘informal’ ways, through self-construction, housing renovation or other activities that lead to population growth and which transform the built environment

INCREMENTAL URBANIZATION

Incremental urbanization in the Global South is often depicted as an anomaly and a hallmark of poverty, conjuring images of slum squalor and inadequate infrastructures.

Informal housing and informal settlements are often brought into conversations of urban growth in the Global South.

In North America, prior to World War II, cities developed through bit by bit, without a main master plan much as cities in the postcolonial world are developing today.



WHAT ARE SOME OF
THE FACTORS THAT
HAVE IMPACTED THE
DEVELOPMENT OF
THE GLOBAL
SOUTH?



HOW DO WE THINK POVERTY
IS IMPACTED BY
URBANIZATION?

THE URBANIZATION POVERTY

Poverty has increased at a much faster rate in urban areas than in rural areas

Creation of and increase in informal settlements or “slums”

“Slums” are a physical and spatial manifestation of urban poverty and inequality

Ongoing shift of global demographics of poverty from rural to urban areas



A stylized globe with a network overlay. The globe is rendered in a golden-brown hue with a textured, almost pixelated surface. It is surrounded by a complex network of thin, light blue lines and small circular nodes, suggesting a global communication or data network. The background is a dark, deep blue with a subtle pattern of small, light blue dots and faint, curved lines, giving it a cosmic or digital feel. The text is centered over the globe.

GLOBALIZATION AND ITS IMPACT ON URBANIZATION

GLOBALIZATION

- The process of increasing economic, demographic, and cultural interaction between people, companies, and governments in a global context.
- This results in greater global economic flows, global interconnectivity and increasing levels of inequality
- Technological advancements have changed how interconnected the world has become

TIME–SPACE COMPRESSION

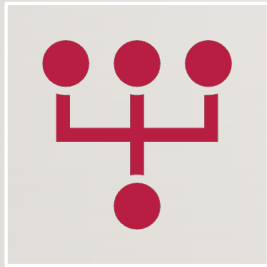
“Time–space compression refers to movement and communication across space, to the geographical stretching-out of social relations, and to our experience of all this”– Dorene Massey

Places appear closer together and more connected – technological improvements in transportation and communication – A “shrinkage” of time and space

Time-Space Compression and globalization are experienced unevenly - Power, race, gender etc, all come together to shape how we move across space.



POWER GEOMETRY



There are some people doing the moving and the communicating and who are in some way in a position of control.



There are groups who are also doing a lot of physical moving, but who are not 'in charge' of the process in the same way at all – refugees, the undocumented migrant workers



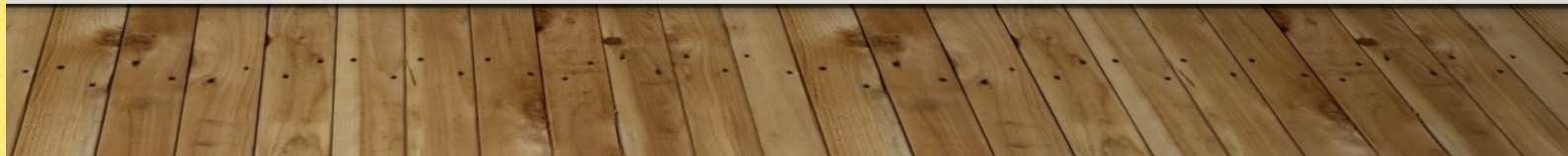
Here the experiences of movement are very different.

POWER
GEOMETRY

What do we think
Massey means by “It is
that the mobility and
control of some
groups can actively
weaken other people”.



BREAK - 5 MINUTES



An isometric illustration of a city. The upper half shows a formal urban area with tall, modern skyscrapers in shades of blue and white, interspersed with smaller commercial buildings. A wide, multi-lane road with a red bus and other vehicles runs through this area. Green spaces with trees and a small park with a fountain are also visible. The lower half, separated by a dark horizontal band, shows an informal settlement. This area is characterized by a dense, irregular arrangement of smaller, simpler buildings, some with red roofs, and a network of narrow, unpaved paths. The overall style is clean and modern, using a color palette of blues, greys, and greens.

URBANIZATION AND INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS

INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS OR “SLUMS”

UN-Habitat Programme (2003) offers a widely accepted definition of informal settlements as residential areas where a group of housing units have been constructed on land to which the occupants have no legal claim, or which they occupy illegally, and where housing is not in compliance with current planning and building regulations.

- Favelas, shanty towns, and squatter settlements, informal settlements vary in size, age, and character, but they share similar characteristics such as precarious land occupancy, inadequate access to basic services, and the use of scrap building materials.
- Informal settlements defy the “order” by operating outside the control, and authorization of the state, especially its zoning and construction laws.





INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS OR “SLUMS”

- As mentioned last week, one of the main ways in which urban areas grow is rural to urban migration. This is also true in the Global South, which can be both voluntary and involuntary.
- Voluntary migration often occurs when migrants arrive in cities in search of better job opportunities and economic security
- Involuntary migration often occur when people are dispossessed of rural land, whether by corporate land grabbing, violent conflict, or the climate crisis

INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS OR “SLUMS”

ADENIYI-OGUNYANKIN, NINGLEKHU, AND
RANKIN (2023)

- New urban residents face challenges of securing housing and making a living - unable to compete with the middle class and the wealthy for limited legal real estate.
- Informal land and housing markets often become the main option.
- More than 1 billion people, approximately one in four urban dwellers, live in precarious settlements.
- Eighty percent of this population are in three regions of the world: East and Southeast Asia (35.8%), sub-Saharan Africa (23%), and Central and South Asia (22%)

INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS OR “SLUMS”

Urban redevelopment agendas or plans have become common in many cities of the Global South.

These large-scale formal redevelopment projects often legitimize the displacement of poorer urban residents whose lives and livelihoods do not "fit" in with plans

Informal settlements are being demolished and their inhabitants are being evicted; unwillingness to comply has in some cases led to state-sanctioned violence.

Those who are displaced are forced to find other, even more insecure housing solutions and sometimes face homelessness

INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS OR “SLUMS”

- The majority of slum dwellers in cities in developing countries earn their living from informal sector activities
 - located either within or outside slum areas
- Most slum dwellers are in low paying occupations such as informal jobs in the garment industry, recycling of solid waste, a variety of home-based enterprises and many are domestic servants, security guards, piece rate workers and self-employed hairdressers and furniture makers.
- When and where are spaces called informal settlements vs slums?



LET US NOW TURN TO HOW PEOPLE ARE LIVING IN INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS

- This term is often called informal urbanism.
- Urbanism points more to the experience and agency of those caught up in those processes. So, how do people in these positions react or respond to the threats of dispossession and displacement they face?

INFORMAL URBANISM

The voices and experiences of the urban poor are often not central in discussions of re-development

Urban poor are rarely taken into consideration in the development of urban theory and the planning of cities.

Urban poor are typically stereotyped as uneducated and incompetent, if not lazy and burdensome

An aerial, high-angle photograph of a slum area. In the center, a large, rectangular building is under construction, with its internal structure visible. The building is surrounded by a dense cluster of smaller, makeshift structures made of corrugated metal and wood. The ground is cluttered with debris, including wooden planks, metal scraps, and other construction materials. Several pieces of heavy machinery, including excavators and trucks, are visible around the construction site. The overall scene depicts a state of urban decay and the process of slum upgrading.

RIGHT TO THE CITY AND SLUM UPGRADING

THE RIGHT TO THE CITY

A philosophical concept and political theory expressed by the French philosopher Henri Lefebvre

- This term does not look at increasing the rights for all people, since some people are already privileged. It is about limiting the rights of some, to increase the rights of others. Creating more equity in society
- It evaluates the relationship between capitalism and urbanization.
- The right of a city's inhabitants to urban life regardless of their legal status as property owners or citizens

TORONTO AND INFORMAL SETTLEMENTS

A Brief History of Toronto Encampments

Toronto Islands

Don Valley

Tent Cities and Protests

Further Reading

Curator Bio

Tent Cities and Protests

Need service in shantytown, 'mayor' tells city



The Globe and Mail, August 20, 2004

Tent-based informal settlements in Toronto have continued till today, emerging as a refuge for those avoiding the city's shelter system or a way to congregate during long-term protests. In the twenty-first century, their emergence is often defined by conversations about whether they should be allowed to exist, for how long, and what amenities should be afforded them. In 2004, *The Globe and Mail* reports on the mayor of a shantytown under the Spadina bridge requesting a porta potty and the city come to pick up baggage. The headline places 'mayor' in quotes threading the report with undertones of incredulity at the situation. The article is quick to note that this is only believed to be a temporary home by the residents in contrast to the waterfront Tenty City that was

bulldozed in 2002.



Until the Covid-19 encampments, the Tent City clearings were Toronto's most profiled and reported-on encampment. The

Until the Covid-19 encampments, the Tent City clearings were Toronto's most profiled and reported-on encampment. The documentary *The Mayor of Tent City* discusses how due to shrinking shelter space and a desire for more autonomy, an encampment was created on Toronto's waterfront was created. Tent City was established on a plot of land that Home Depot had left undeveloped. Due to media-fuelled anxieties about the encampment constituting a blemish on Toronto's image, suggestions of festering criminality, and paternalistic rhetoric, Home Depot under public and municipal pressure evicted those living in the encampments. Some of the residents were afforded rent supplements to support them after their eviction. *Down to This: Squalor and Splendour in a Big-city Shantytown* by journalist Shaughnessy Bishop-Stall documents some of the experiences in Tent City. The clearing of Tent City is perhaps the first recorded moment of such a large-scale informal settlement eviction in Toronto that mobilized both police and private security.



Courtesy of the Toronto Disaster Relief Committee Archives

Please watch - <https://exhibits.library.utoronto.ca/exhibits/show/torontoencampments/tentcityprotests>

“SLUM” UPGRADING

- According the the UN-Habitat - Future policies should go beyond the physical dimension of slums by addressing problems underlying urban poverty.
- Support the livelihoods of the urban poor, by enabling urban informal sector activities to flourish, linking low-income housing development to income generation, and ensuring easy access to jobs
- Policies should address the various dimensions of poverty, including employment and incomes, food, health and education, shelter and access to basic urban infrastructure and services.



“SLUM” UPGRADING

1. Up-scaling and replication of slum upgrading
2. Greater state involvement is needed at both the national and local levels of government
3. Slum policies should involve the poor in the formulation, financing and implementation of slum upgrading programmes and projects
4. Improving security of tenure and housing rights of slum dwellers
5. Urban policies should increasingly aim to create safer cities

“SLUM” UPGRADING

Good, inclusive and equitable urban governance – not only for the rich



Implement urban planning and management policies designed to prevent the emergence of slums, alongside slum upgrading



Investment in city-wide infrastructure

An aerial night view of a city, likely New York City, with a dense network of glowing yellow lines connecting various points across the skyline, symbolizing global connectivity and urban infrastructure. The lines form a complex web of arcs and loops, highlighting the interconnectedness of the city's power and communication systems.

HOW DO THESE KEY DISCUSSIONS CONNECT?

- Trace the connection between global power structures and local urban realities:

How does the power geometry of globalization drive urbanization via the growth of informal settlements, and what are the implications for subsequent slum upgrading initiatives?

DISCUSSION POST

- Please check the discussion tab under the materials for this week on the modules page.
- Upload by the end of class - 1pm.
- 150 – 250 words
- Prompt: What is the right to the city and how should it be used to guide slum upgrading policies and measures?

Next Steps

- I. Complete the course readings for next week and come ensure you attend your tutorial.

Cities and Globalization/Global Cities

- Sassen, Saskia. 2015 [2001]. “The Impact of the New Technologies and Globalization on Cities.” Pp. 651-658 in The City Reader
- Brenner, Neil and Roger Keil. 2015. “From Global Cities to Globalized Urbanization.” Pp. 666-676. The City Reader.

